

Startups

LEAP AHEAD INITIATIVE

For Tech Startups' Funding, Training, And Global Networking

LEAP AHEAD (Launchpad for Tech-Entrepreneurs towards Accelerated Growth and Pioneering AHEAD) is a startup acceleration initiative by STPI, in partnership with the Ministry of Electronics & Information Technology (MeitY) and The Indus Entrepreneurs (TiE) Delhi-NCR. The programme supports tech startups with funding up to ₹10 million, intensive training, mentorship, and global networking opportunities. As the first cohort concludes, EFY's Yashasvini Razdan interviewed STPI Director-General Arvind Kumar about the programme's outcomes, future plans, and its impact on the electronics ecosystem.



ARVIND KUMAR
DIRECTOR-GENERAL, STPI

What have been the key outcomes of the LEAP AHEAD Initiative so far?

The programme was initiated in November 2023. We are currently nearing the completion of the first season, having concluded two stages. Twenty-two startups were shortlisted and taken to TiECon Silicon Valley, where they received favourable responses from global investors, securing commitments of over ₹550 million. The LEAP AHEAD initiative is akin to the Y-Combinator model, teaching founders how to market their products, improve their teams and business models, find the correct product/market fit, and scale their startups into high-growth businesses.

What are the stages of the programme?

The three-stage programme began with a round of in-person pitching

across three tier-2 cities—Bhubaneswar, Vijayawada, and Chandigarh—followed by an online pitching round. Around 546 applications from 27 states participated in this initial round, after which we selected 87 revenue-generating startups for an intensive three-month mentorship programme.

The second stage, which concluded in the first week of May, involved global connections, where we shortlisted 22 startups for TiECon Silicon Valley. These startups connected with mentors and venture capitalists, with three gaining investor interest at this stage. They also received training on pitch refinement in a startup bootcamp and visited the Meta office.

The third stage, currently ongoing, is the co-investment model, where startups are undergoing fundraising rounds, with select startups eligible for

funding of up to ₹10 million against equity participation.

Discussions surrounding the initiation of Season 2 of LEAP AHEAD initiative are under the works.

Will there be ongoing monitoring of each startup's performance after the programme concludes?

Yes, we will follow up with the startups until they graduate and start generating considerable revenue. They receive personalised mentorship and guidance on various aspects, from scaling operations to connecting with investors and building a marketing presence. This structured support is followed by ongoing assistance to ensure sustained growth and success.

How many of the 87 startups are involved in the electronics sector?